



Chapter Title: Contraries in One: Contingency, Analogy, and God in Transcendental Thomism

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Book Title: The Discovery of Being and Thomas Aquinas

Book Subtitle: Philosophical and Theological Perspectives

Book Editor(s): CHRISTOPHER M. CULLEN and FRANKLIN T. HARKINS

Published by: Catholic University of America Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctvqmp2p4.9>

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Contraries in One

Contingency, Analogy, and God in Transcendental Thomism

STEPHEN M. FIELDS, SJ

“Oh to vex me,” said the seventeenth-century poet and divine John Donne, “contraries meet in one.”¹ The history of thought has long venerated the doctrine of analogy as overcoming the paradoxes that mesmerized the Jacobean sensibility. Heraclitus and the Stoics adumbrated it, for instance, in their principle of “the sympathy of the whole,” which claimed that the tensions immanent in the visible world are ultimately reconciled in an underlying invisible harmony.² Plato located analogy’s ground in his anamnestic epistemology, which links sensible realities to the infinite world of spiritual forms.³ Aristotle found it in the *eros* of the mind. Knowledge obtains only because the intellect is impelled by something divine toward which it aims, but never satisfactorily reaches.⁴ In Christianity, analogy has been closely linked with the sacramental vision of reality. Finding inspiration in Bishop Butler’s magnum opus,

1. John Donne, “Holy Sonnet 19,” line 1.

2. Ernst Cassirer, *An Essay on Man* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1944), 94–95 and 222–23.

3. See especially *Phaedo*.

4. Cited in Maurice Blondel, *Action* (1893), trans. Oliva Blanchette (South Bend, Ind.: University of Notre Dame Press, 1984), 388 (original pagination).

John Henry Newman, for instance, spoke of the church as the earthly society that unfolds the hidden economy of grace.⁵ Developing this point more recently, Avery Dulles included analogy in his list of the fifteen indispensable criteria of authentic Catholic theology.⁶

The school of Thomism known as “transcendental” has made its own creative contribution to analogy’s development. Philosophical at root, it has been harnessed by theology as a dogmatic hermeneutic. The Jesuit Joseph Maréchal (1878–1944), a francophone Belgian or Walloon, produced between 1922 and 1926 one of the movement’s groundbreaking works, *The Point of Departure of Metaphysics*.⁷ Most significant is the last of the series’ five volumes, *Le Thomisme devant la philosophie critique*, loosely rendered as *Thomism in Dialogue with Kant*.⁸ Several contemporary philosophers owe their inspiration to Maréchal, including the Canadian Bernard Lonergan (1904–84), the Austrian Emerich Coreth (1919–2006), and the German Johannes Baptist Lotz (1903–92). This study will deal with another German, Karl Rahner (1904–84), Maréchal’s most renowned disciple. It will first explain the logic according to which the Belgian develops his distinctive understanding of analogy. Subsequently, it will explain how Rahner expands his mentor’s insights in order to rethink the traditional Thomist doctrine of God. Two sections constitute this essay; each considers how our thinkers seek to resolve a vexing paradox. The first section concerns the antinomy between contingency and necessity in finite being. The second handles the tension between the dynamism of love and the absolute’s essential simplicity. Whereas analogy solves the first paradox, it encounters steep hurdles when approaching the second.

Maréchal’s approach to the first paradox centers on a controversial thesis. If philosophical realism is to establish metaphysics, precisely as a

5. John Henry Cardinal Newman, *Apologia Pro Vita Sua* (New York: Doubleday, 1989), 132, referring to Joseph Butler, *Analogy of Religion* (originally published in 1736).

6. Avery Dulles, SJ, “Criteria of Catholic Theology,” *Communio* 22 (1995): 303–15, at 305.

7. The origin of the movement is usually attributed to Pierre Rousselot, SJ, *Intelligence: Sense of Being, Faculty of God*, trans. Andrew Tallon (Milwaukee, Wis.: Marquette University Press, 1999 [1908]).

8. Joseph Maréchal, SJ, *Le point de départ de la métaphysique*, 5 vols. (Brussels / Paris: Desclée de Brouwer / Éditions universelle, 1923–26; 2nd ed., 1944–49); see the one-volume redaction, *A Maréchal Reader*, ed. and trans. Joseph Donceel, SJ (New York: Herder and Herder, 1970).

universal science, the tension between necessity and contingency cannot be resolved on the basis of the *a posteriori* alone. The Jesuit emphasizes texts such as *In Meta.* IV, l. 6: “For the first principles are known through the very *light of the agent intellect*.” These principles include non-contradiction, the *a priori* law without which thought is impossible. But the Belgian is firmly committed to the classic hallmark of Thomist realism: namely, that nothing exists in the intellect unless it first obtains in sensibility. Accordingly, first principles, although virtually innate in the agent intellect, can only become explicit because, *a posteriori*, a particular datum of sense is assimilated, abstracted, and judged as real.⁹

Controversy

Other Thomists hotly contest Maréchal’s thesis. These include John Knasas, a contemporary disciple of Étienne Gilson (1884–1978).¹⁰ He argues that our knowledge of necessity and universality, of the infinite, and of God is strictly *a posteriori*. *Ens materiale* is encountered, he claims, not as a finite participation of the infinite, but as the commonality in real things. Sensuous data suffice to objectify being, which, strictly on the basis of this commonality, can only subsequently be affirmed as *esse subsistens*.¹¹ As for “the light of the agent intellect,” this, he says, “is automatically able to abstract the notion of being from which the first principle follows.” In support, he cites *In De An.*, a. 5, co., where Thomas observes that some believe the agent intellect to be “nothing but the ... knowledge of the first ... principles in us.” This “is impossible,” continues the Common Doctor, because these principles are known “through abstraction from the singular.”¹²

In support of his own argument, the Walloon could cite exactly the

9. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 143.

10. John F. X. Knasas, *Being and Some Twentieth-Century Thomists* (New York: Fordham University Press, 2003). For another critique, see Benedict M. Ashley, OP, *The Way toward Wisdom: An Interdisciplinary and Intercultural Approach to Metaphysics* (Notre Dame, Ind.: University of Notre Dame Press, 2006), esp. 44–54. See also Gerald A. McCool, SJ, *From Unity to Pluralism: The Internal Evolution of Thomism* (New York: Fordham University Press, 1989), 117–18, citing Jacques Maritain, *The Degrees of Knowledge*, trans. Gerald B. Phelan (New York: Scribner, 1959), 71–72, 107–8, 128–29; see also McCool, *Unity*, 161–62, citing Étienne Gilson, *Réalisme thomiste et critique de la connaissance* (Paris: Vrin, 1947), chap. 5.

11. Knasas, *Being and Some Twentieth-Century Thomists*, 54.

12. *Ibid.*, 60.

same text. It does not deny that the ground of metaphysics grasped in the first principles can be explained only by a subtle synthesis of the intellect's *a priori* and *a posteriori* ranges. With due respect to some of Maréchal's critics, the crucial issue for him lies not so much in his eagerness to establish a dialogue with the Kantian ego. Nor does it lie in his creative evincing of a transcendental deduction to establish metaphysical realism, however important to his method this may be. It lies in providing a satisfactory answer to the basic question concerning how the human mind can know that which intrinsically transcends the limits of sensuous objectivation. The crucial issue, in short, concerns vindicating a rule considered since Socrates as absolutely fundamental to metaphysics: that like can be known only by like.

The history of philosophy manifests a replete sensitivity to this rule, although its application varies. Henry of Ghent, a contemporary of Bonaventure, agrees that the human intellect can know something of the object *a posteriori* through sensory intuition. Following Aristotle, Henry avers that this knowledge does not exclude the general influence of the first cause, without which no motion is possible. Henry reminds us, however, that knowing *what is true of an object* and knowing *precisely its truth* entail distinct, albeit interrelated, mental operations. Whereas knowing what is true of an object obtains by abstraction from the phantasm, knowing the object's truth as such requires an *a priori* constitutive of mind. As a card-carrying Augustinian, he finds a solution in "illumination."¹³

Kant also posits an intellectually immanent *a priori* as a condition for the possibility of truth. For him, the idea of God arises from the internal dynamics of the transcendental dialectic. It seeks a first cause of the categories, under which the transcendental analytic schematizes the appearances of the world intuited through the transcendental aesthetic.¹⁴ Mind's internal dynamics thus lend great force for Kant to the teleological argument. Kant's *a priori*, however, demonstrates only that the idea of God is logically possible, not that it objectively exists.¹⁵

13. Henry of Ghent, *Summa quaestionum ordinariarum* I, 3, in *Medieval Philosophy: Essential Readings with Commentary*, ed. Gyula Klima (Malden, Mass.: Blackwell, 2007), 105.

14. Immanuel Kant, *Prolegomena to Any Future Metaphysics*, trans. Paul Carus, rev. James W. Ellington (Indianapolis, Ind.: Hackett, 1977), 88–89.

15. Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, trans. Norman Kemp Smith (New York: St Martin's, 1965), 519–20 (A622–23/B650–51).

For his part, Maréchal uses the rule to warrant the following thesis. If the existence of God is to be constitutive of human intelligence, and if being is to be grasped precisely as analogous, then without an interplay with the *a priori* the *a posteriori* will never, of itself, demonstrate infinite being as anything more than regulative of thought. Analogy cannot be grounded in illumination because Thomist realism disavows it. Ironically, however, knowledge of God must be grounded, as Kant claims, in a transcendental dialectic. According to the Walloon, following Thomas, this dialectic affirms infinite being when the mind “corrects” its objective concepts.¹⁶ This correction is also known as *excessus*; it holds high significance for Rahner in *Spirit in the World*.¹⁷ But if Maréchal is to counter Kant’s agnosticism, he must, as a metaphysician, further press a vital question: “How could we perform this correction since, not knowing God directly, we have no way of comparing him with his creatures?”¹⁸ He discovers an answer in his creative analysis of the first principle, “Whatever is, is.”

First Principle

This fundamental axiom of thought, according to the transcendental school, places “essence” in metaphysical unity with itself. In other words, the first principle explains how the subjective species, sensuously intuited as a particular datum from the world, can become, properly speaking, an object of thought. It explains how to resolve the paradox underscored by Thomas in *ST I*, qq. 84 and 86: namely, that our intelligence knows what is necessary and unchangeable, even as it knows the objects of experience that are dependent and variable.¹⁹ If someone were to claim, Maréchal speculates, that the intelligible species and the object of thought are univocally one and the same, then the distinction between contingency and necessity would effectively collapse.²⁰ By itself, the species entails no necessity, either subjective or objective, precisely because

16. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 144.

17. Karl Rahner, SJ, *Spirit in the World*, trans. William V. Dych, SJ (New York: Herder and Herder, 1968), 145, 209, 394–98; see also Thomas Sheehan, *Karl Rahner: The Philosophical Foundations* (Athens: Ohio State University Press, 1987), 205 and 226.

18. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 144.

19. *ST I*, q. 84, a. 1, ad 3, and a. 3, co.; Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 94.

20. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 92.

the species, as a mere accidental modality of thought, constitutes a “simple *pros ti*,” a “what” that is merely directed *toward* objectivation. Only under the first principle can the species emerge in conscious knowledge as an essence. As Maréchal metaphorically opines, when the first principle “freezes” the species precisely in identity with itself, then whatever is (a species), *is* (known precisely as an essence). Because knowledge entails the dynamic self-unification of essence, Rahner, for his part, defines it as “the self-presence of being.”²¹

On account of this freezing, the subjective species, which is only variable, assumes the necessity requisite of an authentic object of knowledge.²² It is therefore contradictory to affirm that the first principle, precisely as *a priori*, can emerge from the variable species as intuited *a posteriori*. On the contrary, in order for any object to be judged precisely as real, existence itself must be implicitly affirmed. Because “whatever is, is,” any proper object of knowledge must be endowed with “a supra-temporal, unchangeable, absolute aspect.”²³ Any object of knowledge must, in short, be “immutably determined [in] relation to the absolute norm of being.”²⁴

Other corollaries follow. On the one hand, the first principle is analytic. As an immutable law of logic, it forbids contradictions. On the other hand, it is also synthetic.²⁵ The Belgian undergirds this last claim by appealing to the transcendental argument of Socrates, also known as retorsion. St. Thomas himself uses it in *ST* I, q. 2, a. 1: “It is self-evident [*per se notum*] that truth exists, for he who denies its existence” admits that “it is true that truth does not exist; but if something is true, then truth must exist.” Even when any radical doubt or denial is asserted or affirmed, the absolute is inescapably asserted and affirmed as the implicit condition of possibility of the doubt and denial. Retorsion represents another form of the first principle. In other words, “whatever is” (that truth does not exist), “is” (truly exists). For this reason, the Jesuit defines retorsion as “an authentic transcendental deduction of the ontological

21. Karl Rahner, SJ, *Hearer of the Word: Laying the Foundation for a Philosophy of Religion*, trans. Joseph Donceel, SJ (New York: Continuum, 1994), 28.

22. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 93.

23. *Ibid.*, 94.

24. *Ibid.*, 93.

25. *Ibid.*, 91.

affirmation.”²⁶ In other words, because logical truth ineluctably entails ontological truth, the first principle, precisely as analytic, is synthetic.

As a synthetic *a priori*, the first principle demonstrates conclusively that relativism, phenomenalism, and agnosticism contain “a hidden contradiction.”²⁷ In fact, the first principle throws the gauntlet down before all nonmetaphysical philosophies. Exposed as artificial, they are, as Hamlet might say, “Hoist with [their] own petar[d].”²⁸ If the *a priori* constitutes the inescapable condition of knowledge, then it follows that the real order, precisely as the objective ground of being, is ratified in every judgment made by the subject. Maréchal’s recovery of retorsion in Aquinas thus lies at the core of his argument.

Retorsion

For his part, Knasas raises probing questions about the efficacy of retorsion. According to its proponents, retorsion, he argues, entails that “any attempt to doubt the framework [of a proposition] employs the framework and so nullifies the doubt.” In other words, “real doubt of the framework presupposes the ability to mentally stand apart from the framework.” Because this “is impossible,” “one concludes that the framework is objective.”²⁹ In response to this understanding, Knasas reminds us of the inescapable context of thought. We are aware, for instance, of how varied contexts can color even our best judgments. Consequently, he believes that retorsion may well be caught in one of the contextual frameworks of our thinking.³⁰ Because these “can be limited and distortive,” the universality of claims established by retorsion is undermined. Retorsion, he continues, is most likely indicative merely of “how we have to think rather than the way reality is.” It thus “fails to beat the Kantian at his own game.”³¹ Because retorsion does not establish metaphysical realism, the first principle may be analytic, as Maréchal claims, but certainly not synthetic. In response to the Transcendental Thomists who

26. *Ibid.*, 96.

27. *Ibid.*, 94.

28. William Shakespeare, *Hamlet*, act 3, sc. 4.

29. Knasas, *Being and Some Twentieth-Century Thomists*, 115.

30. *Ibid.*

31. *Ibid.*, 116.

cite *ST I*, q. 2, a. 1, in which Thomas seems to use retorsion to demonstrate the self-evidence of truth, Knasas argues that presupposed in this text is the fundamental *a posteriori* premise that, according to him, grounds Thomist realism: "Thought is about the real."³² As a result, Thomas is immune to any criticism of retorsion, because he actually does not employ it.

Let us respond by first quoting Maréchal himself. Precisely as a *performatory* contradiction, retorsion entails that:

When you say there is no truth, you affirm implicitly that to your present negative statement there corresponds a certain objective disharmony between thought in general and outside reality... For to admit a relation of truth is tantamount to admitting, outside of your present and subjective thought, "something" which "controls" it, a norm with respect to which it is inevitably either true or false.³³

His claim is threefold. First, retorsion discloses the necessary conditions for the possibility of asserting the proposition that denies truth. Second, in so disclosing these, retorsion renders the proposition incoherent. This incoherence does not obtain on the basis of the framework from which the terms of the proposition emerge. On the contrary, it obtains on the basis of the condition of possibility of any framework precisely as such. Third, this incoherence immediately establishes the correspondence theory of truth as *adequatio rei et intellectus*. The intellect must, in other words, submit to an objective reality: in this case, a necessary norm imposed on it. Retorsion demonstrates, therefore, that when judgments are made, being—the absolute—is implicitly opposed to the relative (the specific terms of the proposition judged). In short, retorsion evinces the first principle as a synthetic *a priori*, because it shows that at least something is known with certainty and hence unconditionally true.

Furthermore, Maréchal argues that "a merely logical contradiction 'in the terms' [of a proposition], independently of any ... concealed ... presupposing, would be unable to yield us ... reality on the rebound. He who tries to demonstrate the absolute necessity of being ... by analyzing concepts ... would commit the ... error of the ontological argument."³⁴

32. Ibid., 128.

33. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 90.

34. Ibid., 210.

Knasas's objection contains this very error. If retorsion were equivalent to Anselm's response to the fool in *Proslogion*, we could surely agree with Knasas that it would hardly convince a Kantian. Anselm, we will recall, argues that his definition of God as "that than which a greater cannot be conceived" is synthetic. If it were not, it would only be analytic. But if it were, then the definition would be intrinsically contradictory. To be its definition, "God" entails extramental existence.³⁵ Disputing Anselm, Maréchal follows Thomas and agrees with Kant that only sensible experience can serve as the ground of knowledge.³⁶ Certainly Kant wanted to avoid Anselm's mistake in his own transcendental deduction of the *a priori* categories. Whatever its purported weaknesses, Kant's deduction, as retorsion, intends to be synthetic.³⁷

The previous quotation from Maréchal receives support in Lonergan's insight that the question of "how the subject gets beyond himself to the known" is misleading. The subject knows himself in and through the first principle.³⁸ As both synthetic and analytic, it shows that other judgments are reasonable and possible for the relentless "task of adding increments to [our] merely habitual knowledge."³⁹ Advancing a similar position, Gaston Isaye (1903–84), another Transcendental Thomist, contends that in retorsion *we* do not possess the fact that we know and that being is intelligible to us. On the contrary, this fact possesses *us*, and it forms the ground of our every act as human persons.⁴⁰

Before concluding this defense of retorsion, let us respond to Knasas's assertion that we could be deluded in our knowledge of the *a priori*. He means, in other words, that the *a priori* may arise merely from one contextual framework of our minds. It seems that this claim would effectively dispense with the principle of noncontradiction altogether. From his perspective as a logician of language, Otto Muck of Innsbruck University offers a confirmation. Building on the semantic theory of Paul Lorenzen of Erlangen University, his careful study, too detailed

35. Anselm of Canterbury, *Proslogion* IV.

36. See *ST* I, q. 2, a. 1.

37. Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, 305–7 (A306–9/B362–66).

38. Bernard J. F. Lonergan, SJ, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding* (San Francisco, Calif.: Harper and Row, 1978), chap. 11.

39. *Ibid.*, 278.

40. Martin X. Moleski, SJ, "Retorsion: The Method and Metaphysics of Gaston Isaye," *International Philosophical Quarterly* 17 (1977): 59–83, at 63.

to reproduce here, shows that the principle of noncontradiction constitutes an *a priori* norm systemically inherent in language as such.⁴¹ The principle is not dependent on any special language. If it were, its origin could then be claimed to lie in some distinctive context or sequestered framework of our thinking. On the contrary, however, the rule is part and parcel of every context and framework. It cannot be denied without a performatory contradiction. Because its negation “is inadmissible” in any language, it grounds “the possibility of the coherence” for “the linguistic expression of any knowledge whatsoever.”⁴² In short, as *a priori*, the first principle imports ontological validity.

Abstraction

Let us now consider Maréchal's view of the role that abstraction plays in harmonizing the *a priori* and *a posteriori* ranges of the intellect. The Walloon draws attention to the Neo-Platonic motif of emanation and return in Thomas's anthropology. According to the Angelic Doctor, the soul is both the agent and the end or *telos* of sensibility. Just as any cause necessarily insinuates itself into its effects, so the soul emanates its influence into the material powers. But it does so in degrees.⁴³ Only at the level of the imagination's synthesis of the intuited datum does the intellect work with direct command on sensibility. Here the intellect serves as the imagination's “immediate principle” and “proximate end.” Because the phantasm's unity *precisely within matter* depends on the intellect's direct insinuation into it, the datum is raised above the level of mere sensibility.⁴⁴ This elevation, however, does not constitute abstraction, however much it does constitute its necessary cause.

Abstraction itself obtains when the unified phantasm, imbued now with spirit, returns to the intellect. It becomes incorporated into “the term of the intellect's natural activity.” As a result, the phantasm bathes in the “light of the agent intellect which is always in act.”⁴⁵ In other

41. Otto Muck, SJ, “The Logical Structure of Transcendental Method,” *International Philosophical Quarterly* 9 (1969): 342–62, at 356 and 359.

42. *Ibid.*, 356.

43. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 132, referring to *ST I*, q. 77, a. 4.

44. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 133.

45. *Ibid.*, 134.

words, the species and the light become one act under the intellect's finality. It must be emphasized, however, as both Maréchal and Rahner do, that the proper act of the intellect in relation to the phantasm never obtains in isolation from the phantasm.⁴⁶ The *a posteriori* is never abandoned in abstraction and judgment, precisely because the phantasm constitutes an intrinsic symbol. Such a symbol makes present in its empirical form another reality.⁴⁷ In other words, the phantasm serves as the necessary ontological medium between the intuited object and the consciously known object, and so as a medium of our affirmations of finite being and of absolute being. The phantasm is thus a fundamental ground of the analogy of being, its *sine qua non*.

Accordingly, precisely because the species is incorporated into the subject's own act, the question for Maréchal becomes: what accounts for the objectivation of the immanent object over against the intuiting, knowing subject? The answer can only be that the object is known as distinctly separate from the subject by contrast with the "speculative unity of being."⁴⁸ What is finite is consciously known precisely as such when it is projected against what is implicitly known as infinite by the subject—the *a priori* first principle, in other words. This *a priori* cannot be known as a concomitant result of knowing the species alone, because, argues the Jesuit, the highest ontological unity that conditions abstraction is only quantitative, not speculative.

Maréchal justifies this last claim by discerning precisely what contribution our intellect makes to the immanent species. He develops his argument on the basis of ST I, q. 84, a. 7, which states that the "quiddity of nature ... exists in corporeal matter." But, says the Belgian, the unity of material quiddities is grounded in quantitative being. As a result, although quiddity can be multiplied indefinitely as instances of their common universal concept, it cannot serve to unify the known object in the ontological order beyond an undetermined number.⁴⁹ According to Maréchal, Kant, for his part, stopped precisely here in his account of the object's unification. For the great Königsberger, the *a priori* relation

46. Ibid., 140. Rahner, *Spirit in the World*, 121; see Sheehan, *Philosophical Foundations*, 202.

47. Karl Rahner, SJ, "The Theology of the Symbol," in *Theological Investigations* 4, trans. Kevin Smyth (Baltimore, Md.: Helicon, 1966), 221–52, at 244.

48. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 141.

49. Ibid.

of the categories to sensibility suffices for judgment. This relation, as we know, obviates metaphysics. Although the judgment in Kant cannot function without the governance of the transcendental dialectic, still, because God, soul, and world are concepts without percepts, the faculty of judgment does not unify beyond the numerical diversity of the categories on the one hand and the numerical diversity of those phenomena that they schematize on the other hand.⁵⁰ Hence, no phenomenon can be noumenally known or, properly speaking, conform to the first principle “whatever is, is.”

Before summarizing my argument, I would like to offer a word in passing on Rahner’s creative retrieval of emanation and return in Aquinas. It lays the foundation for his metaphysics of the *Realsymbol*. Like his Belgian mentor, Rahner understands the soul as a dynamic form that emanates itself in and through the body. The soul infuses the corporeal faculties such that, by means of them, it fulfills its own proper function. In reaching its perfection by means of the body, the soul returns to itself. It incorporates sensible data from the world into its own immanent activity. It thus constructs the raw material of intuition into a proper object of knowledge, whose truth only spirit can posit.⁵¹ The body does not serve as a mere appendage of the soul, much less a hindrance to it. On the contrary, the body constitutes the symbol within which the soul mediates itself “immediately,” as Rahner claims.⁵² This means that the symbol (in this case, the body) contains intrinsically, and makes possible, what it, as an empirical medium, represents (in this case, the person’s analogous knowledge of being). Moreover, being itself—being pure and simple, as well as the being of substances—is “*realsymbolic*.”⁵³ We will soon examine the theological use to which Rahner puts this claim.

Let us now review the conclusions that we have reached thus far. If quantitative being is the highest unity obtainable on the basis of the *a posteriori*; and if, as we have seen throughout our analysis, objectivation cannot obtain by this unity alone; then when Aquinas says that the first principle “comes from without to someone who, as it were, pos-

50. Ibid., 141–42.

51. Rahner, “Theology of the Symbol,” esp. 232–33 and 246–47.

52. Ibid., 244.

53. See Stephen M. Fields, SJ, *Being as Symbol: On the Origins and Development of Karl Rahner’s Metaphysics* (Washington, D.C.: Georgetown University Press, 2000).

sesses it by nature," it is reasonable to infer that this *a priori* is virtually immanent in the agent intellect without in any sense determining the absolute.⁵⁴ For its part, retorsion evinces this *a priori* as synthetic. It therefore follows that "whatever is, is," because every finite judgment implicitly affirms the infinite. The first principle thus contains the seeds of Maréchal's doctrine of analogy.

Analogy

Resolving the paradox of contingency and necessity, the first principle grounds the objectivation of the material world's quiddities. This obtains in an excessus that makes possible the certain affirmation of the existence of God. Because the analogy of being thus springs from objectivation, we must now probe into its conditions of possibility. Earlier it was mentioned that excessus requires the mind "to correct" its determined concepts. In explaining the definition of this term, we come to the heart of Maréchal's originality: his distinctive theory of the intellect's "dynamic finality."

The Belgian first proceeds phenomenologically. He notes that the human intellect experiences in every freshly intuited datum its dynamic capacity to expand. About this expansion, Aquinas himself observes: "Our intellect extends into infinity in knowing. This is shown by the fact that whatever finite quantity may be presented, our intellect can think of a greater one."⁵⁵ Although the knowing subject verifies this dynamism as a psychological necessity, logic also confirms it. The immanently assimilated phantasm is, by definition, relative; it is, after all, specific and determined.⁵⁶ But all determination, as Spinoza reminds us, entails negation.⁵⁷ Negation, however, must imply an implicit affirmation; determination must obtain against some background other than nonbeing.

According to the Jesuit, in our very knowledge of the relative, we implicitly gain access to a higher epistemic range. This can only be what

54. *In Meta.* IV, l. 6; *Maréchal Reader*, 143.

55. SCG I.43.7; *Maréchal Reader*, 164 and 166.

56. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 144.

57. Baruch Spinoza (Letter 50 to Jelles), cited in G. W. F. Hegel, *Hegel's Logic*, trans. William Wallace (Oxford: Clarendon, 1975), 135.

is not relative, but absolute. For his part, Hegel would concur with Maréchal. For instance, Hegel criticizes Kant, who fails to grasp so fundamental an inference. "A very little consideration might show," Hegel says, "that to call a thing finite or limited proves by implication the very presence of the infinite and unlimited."⁵⁸ Accordingly, if nothing more than contingency can be sensuously intuited, and if our grasp of contingency implies the absolute, then, the Walloon concludes, thought constitutes "a movement" toward God (infinite being) as the intellect's final cause. It draws "us constantly 'beyond' that which may still be represented by [determined] concepts."⁵⁹

Not satisfied, however, Maréchal wishes to establish the intellect's dynamic finality as an inescapable law of cognition. He wishes, therefore, to bring it under retorsion. As we know, doing so would establish it as a first principle of thought immune to denial. He begins by asserting that the intellect's dynamism establishes the empirical ground for the possibility of the existence of absolute being. In other words, because thinking begins with sensuous intuition, and because no intuited object can ever halt the mind's movement, the intellect's tendency toward the absolute is existentially necessary for every human subject. Against the Kantian criticism that the notion of the absolute generated by the mind could merely be some finite notion arising from cognition's inner workings, he responds that, because the notion is empirically grounded and subjectively necessary, the absolute must necessarily exist. Because the absolute is necessary in and through itself, it constitutes the universal ground of all possible being, including its own. Because the absolute is necessarily possible, insofar as thinking could not obtain without it, the absolute must objectively exist.

A performatory contradiction thus obtains when the absolute's real existence is denied. The denial is an affirmation that the absolute does not exist as extramental reality. But because the absolute's objective existence is a necessary condition for the possibility of every affirmation, the denial implicitly affirms the absolute's objective reality.⁶⁰ The Walloon thus supplies to the ontological argument what it lacks: an empirical

58. *Hegel's Logic*, 92.

59. Donceel, *Maréchal Reader*, 145.

60. *Ibid.*, 183–85.

and existential ground. It follows that whatever is (God's psychological necessity), is (God's objective existence).

We can now see more clearly how the Jesuit's theory of objectivation follows from the finality of the dynamic intellect. As we noted in the previous section, the immanent species is detached from its unity with the subject's own epistemic act when it is projected against the speculative unity of being. The finite form, assimilated by the subject, is "referred to the proper end of" the mind's dynamism.⁶¹ Because this end is infinite and absolute, the subject is able to acquire a new determination. The contingent datum is known precisely as such. It is "spun off," so to speak, by the mind as it ineluctably moves beyond finitude. To use Maréchal's own metaphor, the object is thus "frozen" in the real order as an entity eternally affirmed as true.

When the Belgian claims that the mind corrects its determined concepts and that it freezes the immanent object, he gives new meaning to excessus. This dialectical act results from the reciprocal action of two distinguishable finalities of the intellect that are actually inseparable. On the one hand, an "antecedent" finality affirms the object as existing independently of the subject. On the other hand, a "consequent" finality is nothing less than the absolute, which alone could confer on the intellect a lasting surcease.⁶² But the consequent finality suffuses the antecedent finality. In other words, objectivation cannot obtain without the mind's supernatural end. It therefore follows that the contrast between finite and infinite that causes objectivation results from the tension between these two dovetailed finalities.⁶³ The finite is grasped as a subordinate end of a process whose adequate end can only be absolute. The hallmarks of truth, necessity and universality, borne by every finite object antecedently affirmed, are derived, then, from the consequent finality.

In sum, analogy, to use another metaphor, can be defined as the dynamic "releasing" of the marks of absolute being in every finite judgment.⁶⁴ The *a posteriori* becomes our gateway, not only to the determined knowledge of created essences, but also to the unqualified field of first philosophy. We may in fact further conclude that the *a posteri-*

61. *Ibid.*, 183.

62. *Ibid.*, 149–51 and 164–65.

63. *Ibid.*, 152, 162, 190–91.

64. See Rahner, *Spirit in the World*, 404–5.

ori becomes for the Walloon an intrinsic symbol of this range. If, as we recall, such a symbol makes present in its empirical form the invisible transcendent, then each and every judgment about the world is naturally endowed with the potential to lead us by *excessus* to God. In the finite datum, therefore, contraries meet. Because of Maréchal's help, this paradox should vex us no longer.

Developing his Jesuit confrere's doctrine of analogy, Rahner attempts to reconcile his own paradox. Given that an analysis of the conditions for the possibility of finite judgments enables us to affirm the existence of God, can we proceed to show, by metaphysics alone, that God is free, loving, and personal? These three terms imply each other. To be free means to act without constraint; to love means to desire an object spontaneously; these qualities, together with intelligence, define the essential distinctiveness of personhood. If Rahner's demonstration is successful, he would accomplish a breakthrough in Thomist philosophy. For his part, Aquinas is influenced by Aristotle, whose discussion of the prime mover makes clear that, however necessary divinity is, it cannot be the subject of love, if by love we imply that the infinite being desires something which it does not have.⁶⁵ This cannot be. The prime mover is pure actuality, immune to change, and perfect because it contemplates its own absolute self-knowledge. Thus spared love, the infinite reality, at least for Aristotle, is also spared freedom and personhood.⁶⁶

Being as Free

Rahner begins his argument in *Hearer of the Word*, his extended essay in the philosophy of religion.⁶⁷ Knowing, he contends, entails volition or will as a necessary cause. Will, traditionally defined as the intellect's ap-

65. See, e.g., *ST* I, q. 20, a. 1; and the critique of Robert O. Johann, *The Meaning of Love: An Essay Towards a Metaphysics of Intersubjectivity* (Westminster, Md.: Newman, 1955), 7. For further analysis, see Stephen Fields, SJ, "Analogy in Aquinas and Denys the Pseudo-Areopagite," in "Thomas Aquinas and the Greek Fathers," ed. Michael Dauphinais, Roger W. Nutt, Andrew Hofer, OP (Naples, Fla.: Sapientia Press, 2019).

66. Aristotle, *Metaphysics* 1072b. For Aristotle, the prime mover is the object of love of all sublunary causes, which it draws to completion as a final cause. See also W. D. Ross's commentary in Aristotle's *Metaphysics* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1924), 1:cxv–cliv.

67. My explication, which involves considerable interpretation, follows *Hearer of the Word*, chap. 7.

petite, implies yearning. It explains the intellect's dynamic drive toward its absolute term. As such, it also explains objectivation. Where there is volition, he continues, freedom is necessarily entailed.

It follows, therefore, that we can, and indeed must, freely will ourselves as contingent beings—at least implicitly. To refuse to do so flies in the face of an indubitable datum of human existence: the incompleteness of our knowledge. To acquire knowledge, we must, over time, ask questions and grope laboriously for answers. To find these, we must inquire, often without success, into the world that confronts us heteronomously as a brute given. To deny this claim only affirms it. Because our knowledge depends on external phenomena lodged in time and space, we find ourselves inescapably finite, contingent, and caused. In addition to these claims, Rahner, borrowing from Maréchal, asserts two further claims already familiar to us. First, it is undeniable that our very contingency serves as the ground of necessity and universality. Second, the analogy of being resolves the tension between our *a priori* and *a posteriori* knowledge. Collectively, these claims enable Rahner to conclude that, if freedom lies in the core of knowledge, then freedom must be intrinsic not only to finite reality but also to God, the infinite being.

An important corollary follows. Because we must will ourselves as contingent, doing so is tantamount to ratifying that we are posited, and do not posit ourselves. In other words, because we are by nature contingent, we are not by nature necessary. We could not have existed. The same applies to the universal cosmos of finite reality. That it, together with ourselves, does in fact exist implies that we are posited by a being who is not contingent but absolute.

Thus far the argument leaves us with little to quibble with. Its next inferences, however, are crucial. We must be posited freely by the absolute. Rahner has already shown that the absolute entails freedom. Accordingly, if the absolute did not posit us freely but necessarily, then we would be necessary, just as our cause is necessary. In that case, we would be posited necessarily by the absolute as beings who could or could not exist. This is a contradiction. If we were posited necessarily by the absolute, we would be beings who must exist. Because we are radically contingent, however, we could not have existed. It follows, he concludes, that it is absurd to claim that contingent beings can be posited necessar-

ily by absolute being. Let us withhold a critique of Rahner's argument until after we have inquired into how he uses it to advance the Christian understanding of God.

Divine Kenosis

Rahner opines that, when facing the mystery of the incarnation, both faith and reason "blink and stutter." This fundamental revelation presents us with a paradox that seems outright contradictory. God, who is immune to change, assumes, in the human nature of Jesus, what God is not. Aiming to obviate an absurdity, theology has traditionally claimed that the change entailed in the doctrine occurs only "in the created reality," not in the divinity. Accordingly, "all change and history ... remain on [the finite] side of absolute gulf." God and the world of becoming are thus prevented "from mingling."⁶⁸ The integrity of God's infinite simplicity thus rests assured.

Rahner, however, finds this approach unsatisfactory. Strictly to divide the predicates "absolute" and "dynamic" between infinite and finite reality misses "by a hairsbreath" what is most important to the incarnation: namely, that human history really is God's own.⁶⁹ The doctrine's paradox is better stated as follows: "He who is unchangeable in himself can *himself* become subject to change *in something else*."⁷⁰ But according to Rahner, this statement itself presents a challenge. "Become" must be defined as a divine predicate without in any sense compromising the absolute's immutability.⁷¹ The German claims to find the synthesis of this dialectic in his interpretation of St. Paul's famous text about the preexistent Word: "He emptied himself, taking the nature of a slave and being made like human beings" (Phil 2:7).

Rahner's interpretation relies on the argument previously discussed. If metaphysics shows that the core of infinite being is loving, free, and personal, then a basis is laid in reason for defining God's self-emptying. The kenotic text means that God "expresses himself" in, through, and

68. Karl Rahner, SJ, "On the Theology of the Incarnation," in *Theological Investigations* 4:105–20, at 113.

69. *Ibid.*, 113n3.

70. *Ibid.*, 113.

71. *Ibid.*, 113–14n3.

because of the love that is also essential to his absolute simplicity. God's love consists of a "prodigal freedom" by which he gives himself away.⁷² In creating the world from nothing, for instance, God freely empties himself by constituting what is "other" precisely as such. In so doing, God manifests his unity without compromising his "unoriginated origin."⁷³ Pure act does not entail stasis but dynamism; and for its part, the divine dynamism does not entail change. Furthermore, in the incarnation, what God has constituted as other than God is brought immanently into God.⁷⁴ God thus creates by taking otherness on; and he takes it on by filling it totally with himself. Accordingly, "the finite itself [is] given an infinite depth and is no longer a contrast to the infinite, but that which the infinite himself has become."⁷⁵ It will be apparent that Rahner uses the metaphysics of the *Realsymbol* to structure his theology of creation and redemption. He thus posits a panentheism that purportedly preserves the freedom of the divine transcendence, as well as the distinct integrity of creation, in which God is nonetheless immanent.

Critique

The first problem in Rahner's extended argument concerns his claim that, under contradiction, we contingent beings must be posited freely by the absolute person. This is questionable. Plotinus has shown us that no contradiction obtains in the absolute's necessary positing of contingent beings. As the intrinsic dynamism of goodness overflows from the One, it constitutes the subsequent grades of reality as images of their preceding archetypes. The very nature of goodness entails the sharing of its bounty. Each emanation intrinsically contains its immediate origin, but in a limited and restricted form. Accordingly, the material world of time and space emerges from the World-Spirit in its proper ontological order.⁷⁶

72. Ibid., 114–15.

73. Ibid., 114.

74. Karl Rahner, SJ, *The Christian Commitment: Essays in Pastoral Theology*, trans. Cecily Hastings (New York: Sheed and Ward, 1963), 49.

75. Rahner, "Theology of the Incarnation," 117.

76. See, e.g., Plotinus, *Enneads* III.7. Hans Urs von Balthasar observes that, strictly speaking, no necessity or freedom can be predicated of the One, rising as it does so beyond reason and

The second problem concerns the vagueness of Rahner's claim that the absolute is free. This cannot mean that God either could or could not create, at least as we contingent persons understand an option to do some act or not. If God is immutable, he cannot be subject to a change of mind. We must therefore say that God, from all eternity, "decides" to create in a way that perfectly accords with his infinite goodness. But then how do we spare God's freedom in the face of the necessary emanation of goodness? We might appeal to the apophatic dimension of analogy. Maréchal reminds us, for example, that absolute predicates, while empirically grounded, defy objectivation. Accordingly, if we can reasonably assert, by analogy, that God is free, and hence personal, then no necessary contradiction seems to obtain in asserting a voluntary dimension to the goodness of the divine person. It is appropriate that reason cannot satisfactorily define this goodness. Nonetheless, if a finite person's goodness is free, it is not unreasonable to posit the same of God's. In sum, although we cannot prove under contradiction that God freely posits us contingent beings, we can still argue from our contingency that God's freedom and goodness are not contradictory.

A related problem in Rahner's argument emerges in another vague claim: that God's freedom entails love. He does not seem to mean *agapē*, the universally disinterested love that Aristotle and Aquinas predicate of divinity. On the contrary, he seems to mean *eros*, the extroverted engagement consistent with the kenotic text of Philippians. His use of this meaning echoes the fifth-century Dionysius, who defines *eros* as convertible with the divine beauty and goodness.⁷⁷ If the conjoining in the divine of freedom and goodness can be spared a contradiction, it is nonetheless certain that *eros* must entail necessity. Because *eros* is intrinsically dynamic, it must aim at an end, as Aristotle and Aquinas perceive, even if this end is freely "decided" from all eternity. Consequently, to be truly free, the divine love must be satisfied within itself. It must entail its own end. Otherwise, if the free motion of love immanent in God does

beyond will. *The Glory of the Lord*, vol. 4: *The Realm of Metaphysics in Antiquity*, trans. Brian McNeil, CRV, et al., ed. John Riches (San Francisco, Calif.: Ignatius Press, 1989), 280–313, at 287, citing *Enneads* V.3.13.

77. See Hans Urs von Balthasar, *Glory of the Lord*, vol. 2: *Studies in Theological Style*, ed. Joseph Fessio and John Riches (San Francisco, Calif.: Ignatius Press, 1984), 144–210, at 189, referring to Dionysius, *De divinis nominibus*, chap. 4.

not terminate in God as its own immanent goal, then it must terminate in a goal other than God. It must terminate therefore in finite being. If it does, then the gratuity of creation is vitiated. To avoid this conclusion, God must be seen to communicate his love to finite being precisely because he is perfectly satisfied. In this case, God's love would be utterly free and gratuitous. Because Rahner's argument does not deal with this problem, its use of the *Realsymbol* to work out a theology of creation and redemption does not, as it currently stands, spare God's freedom, immutability, essential simplicity, and sovereignty.

The last problem concerns Rahner's critique of theology's traditional division, in the incarnate Word, of the predicates "absolute" and "dynamic." Surprisingly, he does not mention the famous doctrine of the "exchange of predicates" (*communicatio idiomatum*) advanced in the patristic age. It claims that, because of the unity-in-diversity of the two unfused natures, what can be positively asserted of one nature can be asserted of the other. Neither the human nor the divine nature is the subject of the exchange, but the one divine person of Christ. It is fitting, therefore, to affirm that Jesus, in Christ, is divine, although not in his human nature. It is also fitting to say that, in the crucifixion, God, in Christ, dies, although not in his own essence.⁷⁸

The point is that the exchange does not inappropriately dichotomize the predicates applicable to each nature, as Rahner avers. On the contrary, it binds them together in one subject, while preserving "the distinctive character of each."⁷⁹ We might well argue, as a result, that this vital teaching of the tradition posits exactly what Rahner says it does not: namely, that God, immutable in himself, can himself become subject to change in something else. In other words, God, in Christ, changes, although not in his divine nature. To further blur the distinction between finite and infinite, as Rahner seems to wish, risks undermining Chalcedon's skillful integration of the analogy of being into the analogy of faith. Such an undermining could render the finite but a mere acci-

78. For more on the exchange, see J. N. D. Kelly, *Early Christian Doctrines* (San Francisco, Calif.: Harper and Row, 1978), chaps. 12–13; for a problematic interpretation of it, see Roger Haight, *Dynamics of Theology* (New York: Paulist, 1990), 139 and 220; this interpretation also appears in the author's *Jesus Symbol of God* (Maryknoll, N.Y.: Orbis, 1999).

79. *The Chalcedonian Decree* (451), in *Christology of the Later Fathers*, ed. Edward Rochie Hardy (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1954), 372–74, at 373.

dent of the infinite substance and thus inevitably devolve Christianity into an ontological idealism inimical to it.

Conclusion

Our study of Transcendental Thomism thus leaves us in the threshold of a perennial problem facing Christian theology: how can faith satisfactorily integrate into its beliefs a metaphysics that is philosophically consistent? On the one hand, I have favorably assessed Maréchal's development of what we might call an "ascending" analogy. Grounded in retorsion, it warrants absolute being on the basis of contingency. On the other hand, I have criticized Rahner's attempt to develop a "descending" analogy from the free and loving absolute to a created order that is redeemed. However problematic his results, Rahner, I must in all fairness admit, takes up the more challenging task. If we concede with him that metaphysics can warrant God as *eros*, then positing a cogent descending analogy still awaits a happy handling of the following aporias. First, the dynamism of God's *eros* must terminate in itself so as to spare the divine's essential simplicity. Second, the otherness of creation must be shown to spring from the divine love without constituting an accident of the divine substance. Third, the redemption must be intrinsically connected to creation without constituting a divine emanation required for the divine to reach its own perfection. It may well be possible to develop the metaphysics of the *Realsymbol*, in tandem with the exchange of predicates, to accomplish these tasks. Those who try will owe as much to the seminal genius of the intrepid German as he owes to the great Walloon's.⁸⁰

80. For such an attempt, see Stephen M. Fields, SJ, "God's Labor, Novelty's Emergence: Cosmic Motion as Self-Transcending Love," in *Love Alone Is Credible: Hans Urs von Balthasar as Interpreter of the Catholic Tradition*, ed. David L. Schindler (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Eerdmans, 2008), 1:115–40.